Then they both came over for a chat; Victoria knew Madonna and I'd met her at Madison Square Garden the night I arrived in New York after France 98. But Michael Jordan? I was like a little kid, couldn't think of what to say to the bloke. It was some night. And by the Monday, it was all round Old Trafford. Dave had started telling people as soon as he got home. All day at training it was about Saturday night with Becks and Michael Jordan:

'What was he like? What was he like?'

I get a genuine thrill from meeting people like that: superstars as far as I'm concerned, whether they're sportsmen or rappers or actors. Dave Gardner's the one who ends up hearing about them all. Every time I go to a party there seems to be someone there I'll get excited about saying hello to: an Elle McPherson or a Michael Jackson or a Michael Caine. Most people would just think I was name-dropping. But Dave's known me long enough to see it for what it is. I still get nervous—thrilled—in the company of the people I admire. If I meet one of them I can't keep it to myself. I always have to ring up the next day to tell Dave.

An amazing part of my life—of life with Victoria—is that, sometimes, those people I'm nervous before meeting and tongue-tied when I do turn out to become friends. I met Elton John at a Versace fashion show in Italy. He was sitting next to me and did all the hard work of the 'hellos' and 'how are yous'. He'd actually met Victoria a couple of times before and just went ahead and introduced himself. After what he's done in his life, I should think Elton's long since got past being shy in situations like that. We got on really well: there just felt like an instant connection. We started spending time together and we've continued to ever since. Elton and David Furnish are Brooklyn's godparents and probably the closest friends Victoria and I have ever made as a couple. Maybe that's because, as a couple, they're like us in so many ways: very much in love and not afraid to show it. They're incredibly generous: almost the first thing Elton did the afternoon I met him in Italy was to offer Victoria and me their place in the South of France as somewhere to go if we ever needed to get away from it all.

Meeting new people, even for a shy one like me, is a pleasure. There are some people, though, who meeting is more like a privilege: the Queen; the Prime Minister; the greatest sportsman of all time, Muhammad Ali. In May 2003, straight after the end of the soccer season, we had an England trip to South Africa. I was on the wrong end of a pretty clumsy tackle in our game against their national team: another weird injury. I broke the scaphoid bone between the wrist and thumb on my right hand and spent the next couple of